disagree. As the citadel at Dholavira suggests, defence was a key consideration. The times and technologies may have been different, but human nature was the same.

In front of the citadel there is a large open ground that could have been used for many purposes—military display, sport, royal ceremonies or perhaps the annual parading of the gods. Archaeologists have found tiered seating for spectators along the length of the ground. Beyond the ceremonial grounds was the planned area where the common citizens lived. This division into a Citadel and Lower Town is quite common in larger Harappan settlements. Interestingly, as the city grew, it continued to attract migrants who could not be fitted into the planned city. This led to the growth of informal settlements just to the east of the original Lower Town. As we shall see, the problem with slums is a recurring theme in India's urban history and we find them in Mughal Delhi, colonial Bombay and in virtually every modern Indian city. The difference is that the political leadership of Dholavira responded by expanding the urban limits and incorporating the slums into the city. According to Dr R. S. Bisht, who led the excavation of the site, we can still discern how the civic authorities redeveloped the slums and imposed Harappan municipal order on them. Thus, Dholavira ended up with three sections—the Citadel, a Middle Town (i.e. the old Lower Town) and a new Lower Town (the new extension).

The city also had to respond to the vagaries of nature. Dr Bisht mentions earthquakes that repeatedly affected Dholavira, including a particularly severe one around 2600 BC. [3] We were violently reminded of the tectonic instability of the region when an earthquake measuring 7.8 on the Richter scale killed 20,000 people in the state of Gujarat on 26 January 2001. The epicentre was not far from Dholavira.

Thus, the picture is not the popular one of a rigidly pre-planned city but of an evolving urban settlement that was responding in various ways to natural and human challenges. When one visits an archaeological site, one tends to admire the ancient masonry in isolation. In reality, Dholavira was a living city that would have been crowded with soldiers, traders, artisans,